THE EASE OF LIVING

The Kochi water metro project was envisaged to reduce pollution and traffic congestion in the city and also ease access to the mainland for the islanders. To that end, it has identified 15 routes for development, connecting 10 islands along a backwaters network that spans 78 km. When fully operational, a fleet of 78 electrically propelled hybrid ferries will ply to 38 jetties along these routes, integrating the waterway system to the public transport network of the city.

The Rs 1,137 crore project, implemented by Kochi Metro Rail Ltd (KMRL) with major funding support from Germany's KfW Development Bank (60 per cent) and the state and Centre contributing (20 per cent each), is billed as the first of its kind in India. Currently, the water metro operates 18 boats connecting 10 terminals on five routes and has a daily average ridership of 6,000 commuters. "This is a new travel experience for Kochi, a green and faster public transport system," says Kochi Water Metro CEO Loknath Behera. "It also provides ease of travelling for daily commuters. Right now, if you use your car to travel from Fort Kochi to the high court area, it'll take over an hour. The Water Metro will get you there in 19 minutes, and for just Rs 40," adds the former state Director General of Police, who feels that such zero emission public transport systems hold the key to saving our cities in the future. Water Metro officials say that when fully operational, the service will lower carbon emissions in Kochi by 44,000 tonnes annually.



"Zero emission public transport systems like the water metro hold the key to saving our cities in the future"

-LOKNATH BEHERA

CEO, Kochi Water Metro

Right now, though, Kochiites have not entirely warmed to the 24-metre-long air-conditioned ferries, possibly because there is still a long way to go before all the routes are connected. It's a huge hit with the tourists, though, who can take in the backwaters and the sights including Fort Kochi, Mattancherry and other historical monuments on the islands within a short time on one of the ferry rides. The Water Metro is eyeing an operational break-even "in a couple of months" (it launched its services on April 23, 2023) and is inching closer to its average daily ridership target of 7,000. It passed an important milestone on October 30 last year when it crossed the 3 million passenger-mark. The service could well add another million before it turns two this April. Call it smooth sailing. ■



HOW IT TRANSFORMED MY LIFE

"I know I'm helping to keep the future generation healthy"

ASTRID STEREENA MATHEW, 25

Lawyer, Kerala High Court

A lawyer by profession, Astrid says the best part about the Water Metro ride is that it relaxes her. Earlier, she used to take the bus, spending almost an hour to reach office at the high court from her home in Veli, a suburb in Fort Kochi. Taking the Water Metro from the Fort Kochi jetty, she reaches her office now in just 20 minutes. A first-generation lawyer, she joined her law firm after passing out from Ernakulam Government Law College. "I also love the Water Metro for another reason. It's green and does not disturb our sensitive marine ecosystems. We need public transport systems that are less polluting. I don't mind paying more for my daily trip because I know I'm contributing towards keeping the future generation healthy," says Astrid. Still, she would like it if the Water Metro reduces fares for everyday commuters, saying attractive packages will encourage more people to opt for it. ■